

Lecture 7

Impromptu Speech & Speech Practice

ENG 111 • Public Speaking

Today

Think • Organize • Speak

Practice

Pairs • Groups • Mini
speeches

Goal

Speak clearly with little
preparation

Learning objectives

By the end of the class, you should be able to...

Explain what an impromptu speech is and why it matters.

Organize a short speech quickly using a simple structure.

Use an opening, 2–3 clear points, and a closing.

Manage hesitation, repetition, and nervousness.

Deliver a short impromptu speech and give useful peer feedback.

What is an impromptu speech?

A speech delivered with little or no preparation.

Prepared speech

You know the topic in advance.
You have time to research, organize, and rehearse.

Impromptu speech

You receive a topic shortly before speaking.
You must think, organize, and speak quickly.

Where do we use it?

Class discussions • interviews • meetings • presentations • social situations • unexpected questions

The 30-second thinking plan

Do not try to write the whole speech.

1. CLAIM

What do I think?

Choose ONE main idea.

2. REASONS

Why do I think this?

Choose 2 reasons or examples.

3. EXAMPLE

Can I make it concrete?

Add a personal or familiar example.

4. CLOSE

What should listeners remember?

Repeat the main idea.

A simple structure: PREP

Use this when you have only a few seconds.

P — Point

State your answer or opinion.

“I believe university students should...”

R — Reason

Give a reason.

“One reason is that...”

E — Example

Give a specific example.

“For example...”

P — Point again

Return to your main idea.

“So, overall...”

Sample impromptu speech

Topic: “Should university students have part-time jobs?”

Sample response

“I think part-time jobs can be useful for university students if they can manage their time.

First, a job can help students develop practical skills such as communication, teamwork, and responsibility. For example, a student who works in a café may become more confident when speaking with different people.

However, students should not allow work to damage their studies. So, part-time work can be valuable when students keep a healthy balance between work and university.”

Notice the structure

The speech is short—but it still has a clear shape.

Opening

“I think...”

Clear position

No long introduction

Middle

Reason + example

Use simple transitions:

First • For example • However

Closing

Return to the main idea.

“So, overall...”

End confidently.

Useful speaking starters

When your mind goes blank, use a starter.

Giving an opinion: “I believe that...” / “In my view...”

Buying thinking time: “That is an interesting question. I would say...”

Giving a reason: “One reason is...” / “The main reason is...”

Giving an example: “For example...” / “A good example is...”

Adding a contrast: “However...” / “On the other hand...”

Concluding: “So, overall...” / “For these reasons...”

What if you need thinking time?

A pause is better than filling every second.

GOOD

Pause for 2–3 seconds.

“Let me think about that.”

“That’s an interesting question.”

AVOID

“Umm... umm... like... you know...”

Repeating the same phrase many times.

REMEMBER

A short pause can make you sound thoughtful—not unprepared.

Activity 1: Pair practice

Think → Speak → Feedback

Work with a partner.

Student A picks a topic and gets 30 seconds to think.

Speak for 60 seconds using PREP.

Student B gives ONE strength + ONE suggestion.

Switch roles.

Feedback sentence

“Your strongest point was...”

“One thing to improve is...”

Pair practice: topic cards

Choose one topic for each round.

Topic 1

Social media does more harm than good.

Topic 2

The best way to relax is...

Topic 3

Students should / should not attend every class.

Topic 4

One skill every university student needs.

Topic 5

Is online learning better than face-to-face learning?

Topic 6

A small habit that can improve student life.

Activity 2: Group challenge

Groups of 4–5 • Build a speech together

Choose ONE topic from the list.

Person 1: opening + point

Person 2: reason

Person 3: example

Person 4: counterpoint or second reason

Person 5: conclusion (if your group has 5 members)

Then choose one speaker to deliver the 2-minute speech.

Challenge

You have 4 minutes to prepare.

Group challenge topics

Try to include different viewpoints.

Should attendance be compulsory at university?

Should students be allowed to use AI for academic work?

Is a four-day university week a good idea?

Should universities offer more practical courses?

Does technology make communication better?

Activity 3: Impromptu speaking circle

Fast rounds • Everyone speaks

Stand or sit in a circle.

One student receives a topic.

10 seconds to think.

Speak for 45–60 seconds.

Next student gets a new topic.

Class listens for one clear point and one good example.

Rule

No one is expected to be perfect.
The goal is to practice.

Impromptu topic bank

Use familiar topics first; increase difficulty later.

Your favorite place on campus

A person who has influenced you

One thing you would change about university life

The best advice you have received

Morning classes: good or bad?

One app you could not live without

Books vs. movies

Living in a big city

Is failure necessary for success?

What makes a good friend?

How to deliver: voice + body

Your ideas matter—but delivery helps the audience follow them.

VOICE

Speak loudly enough.

Vary your pace.

Pause after important ideas.

Avoid speaking too fast.

EYE CONTACT

Look at different listeners.

Do not stare at your notes.

Use eye contact when making your main point.

BODY

Stand comfortably.

Use natural gestures.

Keep your posture open.

Avoid distracting movements.

FACE

Show interest.

Use natural facial expression.

Let your expression support your message.

Mini feedback checklist

For peer feedback after each speech

- ☐ Was the main point clear?
- ☐ Did the speaker give a reason or example?
- ☐ Was the speech organized?
- ☐ Was the voice easy to hear?
- ☐ Did the speaker make eye contact?
- ☐ Did the speaker finish clearly?

Keep feedback constructive

Start with one thing that worked.

Quick practice: 60 seconds

Topic: "One thing every student should learn before graduation."

30 sec

Write only 3–5 keywords.

Do NOT write full sentences.

60 sec

Deliver your speech.

Point → Reason → Example
→ Point

Partner

Listen carefully.

Give one strength and one suggestion.

Common problems—and quick fixes

“I don't know what to say.”

Start with your opinion.
Then ask yourself: Why?
Then: Can I give an example?

“I keep repeating myself.”

Stop.
Pause.
Move to a reason or example.
Use a transition.

“I'm nervous.”

Breathe before speaking.
Slow down.
Look at one friendly face first.
Focus on the message—not
perfection.

Marked impromptu speech: what to remember

Your course outline allocates 10 points to the impromptu speech.

Your goal is not to sound memorized.

Show that you can organize an idea quickly.

Make your main point easy to identify.

Support it with reasons/examples.

Use clear verbal and non-verbal delivery.

Practice today so the marked delivery feels more manageable.

Exit ticket

Before you leave, answer these three questions.

1

What is one thing you learned about impromptu speaking?

2

What is one speaking habit you want to improve?

3

Which strategy will you use when you get stuck?

Final reminder

Think clearly. Speak simply. Connect with your audience.